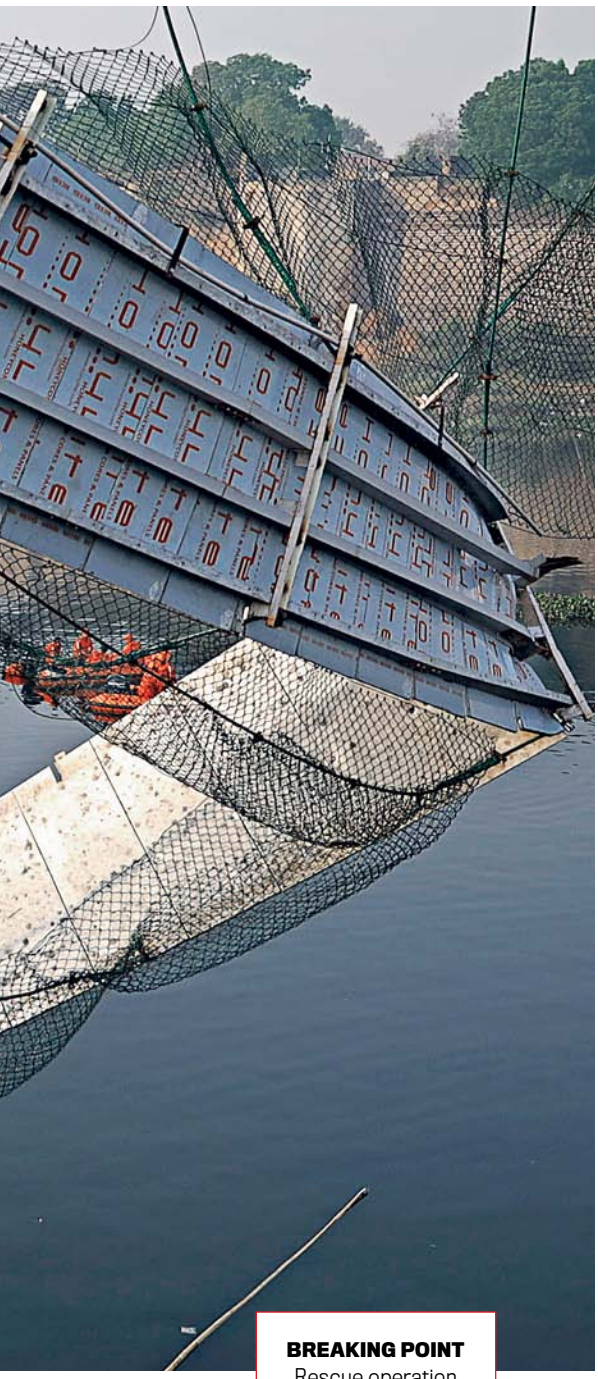
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By Jumana Shah



NANDAN DAVE

BREAKING POINT
Rescue operation at the site of the bridge tragedy in Morbi, Gujarat

THE FESTIVE SPIRIT OF DIWALI ENDED ON A horrifying note in Gujarat as a suspension bridge across the Machchhu river in Morbi town collapsed on October 30, killing at least 134 people and injuring many more. Coming just ahead of the expected announcement of the assembly election schedule, the timing, location and context of the tragedy portend ill tidings for the ruling BJP. Even though both its main rivals—the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) and the Congress—refrained from starting a war of words until rescue operations were over, the subtext of the accident hung heavy in the air. The angst provoked by the tragedy will likely have a significant impact on the crucial election.

But first the horrible disaster demands a fixing of the culpability on several fronts. The bridge was thrown open to the public without a safety audit by the Morbi municipality, which had given the contract of maintaining and repairing it—with no mention of such audit requirements—to the Oreva Group, makers of the Ajanta brand of wall clocks. When asked, Morbi municipality chief Sandeepsinh Jhala said the bridge had been reopened without their permission. After its inauguration by Oreva chairman Jaysukh Patel, the bridge was used for four full days, before it collapsed. It is not known why the municipality officials made no attempt to shut it down for not having a safety certificate.

The nine persons arrested in the wake of the disaster so far include two managers and two ticket clerks on Oreva's payroll, as well as two contractors (responsible for repairing the bridge) and three